

Neeraj Chopra's STAR POWER FUELS BUZZ

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Neeraj Chopra has been a matchless pathbreaker in Indian athletics for close to a decade. He has brought home glories of the unprecedented kind — World Championships title, Olympic medals, Diamond League crowns and the hallowed 90-metre mark.

A byproduct of such blinding success is that it bequeaths one with immense soft power, something only cricketers and movie stars usually possess in this country.

Neeraj, though, never wielded the full potential of this fame. His public appearances were scarce, his social media activity mellow, and his endorsements never over-the-top.

But over the last few months, Neeraj was forced to come out of this cocoon and brandish his influence, following the announcement of the inaugural edition of Neeraj Chopra Classic, a top-tier javelin throw event set to display India's potential to host big-ticket events.

As the co-host of the NC Classic, the reigning world champion went out of his way to indulge in the organisational mire of the event. In addition to inviting elite international throwers, he dove head-first into the

decision-making process — subduing the spice level of athletes' meals to picking the choice of stadium music during the event buildup.

Neeraj and his team's efforts yielded the results as the maiden NC Classic surged into a resounding success. Nearly 15,000 fans flocked to the Sree Kanteerava Stadium on July 5 to cheer on a top-class field, while millions watched it on screens across the world

Befittingly, Neeraj won the title, with an 86.05m throw in the third round, as he staved off challenges from Kenya's Julius Yego and Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage.

The attention garnered by the NC Classic astounded the likes of Rio Olympic gold medallist Thomas Rohler, who has been to nearly all corners of the world as a competing athlete.

"Fifteen thousand people for only javelin is unique. To be honest, I have never seen something like this," said